POU33201 — Reading response papers

10% of the module mark · Michaelmas Term 2026

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Summary

Weight	10% of the module mark total
Length	500–700 words, +/- 10%
How many	Two: one in teaching weeks 1–6, one in teaching weeks 8–12
Which weeks	Your choice, within each half of term
Due	Wednesday 23:59 of the week you choose
Marking	Each paper receives a mark; the two together make up the 10%
Submission	Blackboard (Turnitin) — one item for each half of term, Assignment Submission Form as page 1

What they are

A response paper is a short piece of **thinking**, not summary: take the week's required readings and do something with them — challenge an argument, apply it to a case the author didn't use, put two readings into conflict, or connect the reading to something happening now.

The test: could someone who has done the reading learn something from your response? Merely restating the argument fails that test; arguing with it passes.

What a good one probably looks like

- Leads with **your claim**, not the author's.
- Uses the reading **precisely** — one concept or finding, named.
- Brings **a case or comparison** the reading didn't use.
- Ends with a genuine **question for yourself or your classmates or future research**.

But you can do many different things with the response paper, it doesn't have to match this format. Other options that you could address:

- What the argument requires in order for it to be true

- A case it fits badly (name the case)
- Something in the news that the reading explains, or fails to explain
- Whether you believe it, and what an alternative explanation might be
- Two readings that disagree, and why
- Something you really didn't understand in the readings

It should be clearly written, spellchecked, and free of errors that inhibit understanding.

You do not need sources beyond the week's readings. You don't need to include a full, formal bibliography (though you can do so), but you should include a brief citation, a list of works referenced, or some other way of noting what you are referring to or where your ideas are coming from.

Generative AI

Permissions for this assessment, in the vocabulary of the School of Social Sciences and Philosophy Assignment Submission Form:

Submission-form category	This assessment
No GenAI used	This is the expected answer.
Brainstorming	**Not permitted.** The point of the exercise is that *you* had a reaction to the reading.
Research/learning assistance	**Permitted for one thing only:** clarifying a term or passage you could not follow after genuinely trying. Not for summarising the reading — asking a model what an article says instead of reading it defeats the whole component.
Writing assistance	**Not permitted.** These are short, and they exist to show you did the reading and thought about it. Spellcheck is fine.
Direct AI content inclusion	**Not permitted.**
Other use	Describe it on the form. If in doubt, ask me *before* the deadline; asking is never held against you.

The Assignment Submission Form must be page 1 of each response paper, as for all written work. A submission without one is not accepted.

Word limits, late work and extensions

As for every piece of written work in this module: see the module outline.